the past, Indonesia, Bangladesh, Afghanistan, and many other places, including Turkey and Iraq, were Buddhist countries, but now they are lost'.[58]

The Dalai Lama has challenged this interpretation of Buddhism and has reported that he urged Aung San Suu Kyi to act over the continued repression of the Rohingyas in particular and Muslims in general.[59] He deemed her refusal to respond as 'very sad. In the Burmese case I hope Aung San Suu Kyi, as a Nobel laureate, can do something'.[60] He later raised the issue of the plight of the Rohingyas once more, stating that 'If Buddha would come at that moment, he definitely would save or protect those Muslims'.[61]

Unfortunately, the Dalai Lama represents a different strand of Buddhism, and this severely limits his influence. He comes from the Vajrayana[62] tradition, a sub-school of Mahayana Buddhism, which became dominant in Nepal from the fifteenth century. The Vajrayana tradition tends to stress social inclusivity but places greater emphasis on individual actions. It shares with the Mahayana tradition a focus more on the acts of the individual[63] as the basis for individual enlightenment. As such, it does not have Theravada Buddhism's focus on the wider polity as having to be pure from other influences, nor does it stress the importance of life within a monastic setting as a precondition for further spiritual progression. For many practical intents and purposes, the Theravada tradition has little in common with the strands of contemporary Tibetan Buddhism. Thus, while in the eyes of the West the Dalai Lama appears to speak for all Buddhists, in contemporary Myanmar, as one journalist argued, the 'views of the Dalai Lama are equivalent to the pope speaking to Protestants'[64] in the context of early modern Europe's religious wars.

The Dalai Lama is not the only person of international renown to have tried to contest the extremist narrative, especially now that the Buddhist extremists are identifying anyone who does not fully agree with them as traitors. Concern about this trend has led UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon to warn that such groups risk 'being swept up by a rising tide of extremist sentiment against other groups … This betrays the peaceful teachings of the founder, Lord Buddha'. He insisted that Myanmar's 'leaders must speak out against divisive incitement … They must promote